

School of Health & Social Sciences

CPC 512: Family Systems Therapy

Cohort 17B – Thursday (PM)

5 Credits
Effective Date (09/01/2023)

07/02/2026 to 09/17/2026

Faculty & Contact Information

Primary Faculty: Renee Hock, DCP, ACS-RCC, CMPC (she/her)
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*Access to the Internet is required.
All written assignments must be in Microsoft-Word-compatible formats.
See the library's APA Style Guide tutorial for a list of APA resources.*

Vision, Mission, and Values

The vision of CityU's Master of Counselling Program is to educate skilled, diverse, socially just psychological practitioners. Our mission is to prepare culturally competent clinicians to work effectively with individuals through our practitioner-scholar-advocate model. This brings real-world experience into the classroom and emphasizes the core principles of reconciliation, diversity, equity, and inclusion. Our core program values are reconciliation, diversity, advocacy, flexibility, connection, and healing.

Territorial Acknowledgement & Statement of Inclusion

We acknowledge that many of the staff, faculty and students in the Master of Counselling Program at City University in Canada live, work and study on the traditional territory of the Coast Salish Peoples, the xʷməθkʷəy̓əm (Musqueam), səliwətaʔ (Tsleil-Waututh), and Skwxwú7mesh (Squamish) First Nations in Vancouver, British Columbia.

CityU honours human diversity in all its forms and is committed to the principle of universal human dignity. We further acknowledge that our learning community is greatly enriched through the voices and perspectives of staff, faculty, and students from all intersections of society including BIPOC, all genders, sexualities, and relationships, and diversely-abled communities.

Course Description

This course introduces students to classic and contemporary family theories and their clinical applications. Students will explore the history and evolution of family therapy with a special focus on diversity and the sociocultural context(s) within which families are embedded. A wide range of traditional and non-traditional family models will be examined (e. g., nuclear families, blended families, Queer families etc.), including students' own family histories and their impact on students' development.

Consideration of Social Justice Issues

City University in Canada is committed to social justice, access, and inclusion. Throughout their studies in the Master of Counselling Program, students are invited to reflect on a range of social justice questions as follows:

- What values, biases, and assumptions are embedded in our dominant society's depiction of a "normal family?"
- How does your cultural background influence the relationship and power dynamics in your family?
- How might the implicit assumptions embedded in your own family dynamics serve as a barrier to understanding family dynamics with a client from a different culture?

Course Resources

The list of required textbooks is available through CityU Library (Leganto System).
Please note that student access will be available 1 month before the start of the quarter.
<https://library.cityu.edu/researchguides/readinglists/students>

Program Outcomes

The content of this course aligns with the following Program Outcomes:

PO 2 Counselling Theory: Articulate and apply a range of coherent theoretical approaches that are relevant to clients' concerns and aspirations.

- 2.1 *Counselling Theory*: Analyze a range of traditional and contemporary counselling theories, their sociocultural contexts, and their applicability to individual, couple, family, and group counselling.
- 2.2 *Client Goals*: Evaluate clients' treatment goals from a range of theoretical perspectives appropriate for clients' identities, culture and context.
- 2.3 *Application*: Apply theoretical models to develop and implement treatment plans effectively.

Course Assignments and Grading

The grades earned for the course will be derived using CityU's decimal grading system, based on the following:

Overview of Required Assignments	% of Final Grade
Genogram/Family Mapping Paper	30%
Peer Review Group Report	10%
Assessment and Intervention Presentation/Project	20%
Collaboration	20%
Case Conceptualization	20%
Total	100%

Course Assignment Details

Genogram and Family Mapping Paper

Understanding the influence of one's family of origin is a critical professional competency for developing therapists.

For the first part of this assignment, students who are able will create a family genogram of three to four generations, including some or all of the following information: 1) dates of birth; 2) genders; 3) ethnicity; 4) education; 5) occupations; 6) marriages; 7) divorces; 8) births; 9) deaths; 10) medical issues; 11) psychological struggles; and 12) significant losses/accomplishments.

As family of origin history can sometimes present challenges for students in completing this assignment, students have the option of employing an alternative mapping tool such as an ecomap or structural map. Alternatively, students may use a fictitious family in the genogram for this assignment.

For the second part of this assignment, students will write a paper reflecting on significant interactional patterns between and among family members on their map. Students' insights will be supported with scholarly citations and the use of course concepts. Students will discuss specific ways in which the identified patterns or family of origin dynamics, including power dynamics, may influence their therapeutic style. Opportunities for personal growth and transformation should be clearly articulated and explored.

This paper should be 6 to 8 pages, double-spaced, using a minimum of five to eight peer-reviewed sources from the past 5 years. APA formatting and citations are mandatory as we are seeking to develop your scholarly writing skills through this process.

Grading Criteria	Grade Points
Genogram/Alternative Map	10 Points
Evidence and Support (Scholarly Sources)	20 Points
Analysis and use of Course Concepts	20 Points
Professional Ethics	20 Points
Cultural Competence	20 Points
Self-Awareness	10 Points
Total	100 Points

Peer Review Group Report

Peer review is a core academic activity in which colleagues support one another's professional development by offering feedback on each other's scholarly work. Working in small groups, students will provide classmates with feedback on their in-class interventions presentation addressing the following questions:

- 1) What did we appreciate about one another's work?
- 2) What did we find challenging about one another's work?
- 3) What changes did we recommend to improve one another's work?

The peer review for this course will be completed as part of an in-class activity.

Grading Criteria	Grade Points
Organization and Coherence	10 Points
Evidence and Support	20 Points
Analysis and Use of Course Concepts	20 Points
Evaluating Information	20 Points
Self-Reflection	20 Points
Participation	10 Points
Total	100 Points

Assessment and Intervention Presentation/Project

Working in small groups, students will present a practical intervention from one theoretical perspective used for assessment and treatment in family therapy. The presentation will introduce central themes and concepts related to the theory chosen. Each group will also present a video or in-class role-play demonstrating the application of the theory in the form of a simulated family therapy intervention. Students will facilitate a class discussion to critically examine the therapeutic perspectives explored.

Students will share their experience of planning and executing the counselling session, discuss challenges, and offer critiques related to the process and theoretical approach. Peers will then have an opportunity to offer feedback, practice the intervention they observed, or another intervention based on this theoretical approach.

Students will have class time to prepare for their role play/presentation.

Grading Criteria	Grade Points
Organization and Coherence	10 Points
Diversity & Collaboration	20 Points
Analysis and use of Course Concepts	20 Points
Professional Ethics	20 Points
Cultural Competence	20 Points
Oral Presentation	10 Points
Total	100 Points

Collaboration

Students may earn marks for collaboration throughout the course. The in-person class portion of this course depends heavily on practical in-person activities and discussion designed to foster skill-based competencies necessary for clinical work in a counselling setting. For these activities to be meaningful, the student must be prepared, having done prior reading and be willing to engage with class members during group discussions and practice activities to help to foster a collaborative learning environment. Actively seeking to help promote safer spaces within the class by recognizing, respecting, and supporting differences between classmates and the instructor will also be considered for assessment purposes.

Grading Criteria	Grade Points
Communication	30 Points
Self Reflection & Compassion	30 Points
Self-Awareness & Self-Regulation	40 Points
Total	100 Points

Case Conceptualization

Working in groups, students will complete a case conceptualization based on a set of framing questions. Students will analyze a case study by selecting one of two options provided to them by their instructor for the purpose of this assignment.

The case conceptualization should be 5 to 6 pages, double-spaced, using a minimum of five to eight peer-reviewed sources from the past 5 years. APA formatting and citations are mandatory as this assignment will be assessed to help prepare students for their upcoming comprehensive exam process.

The case conceptualization will be completed as a group in-class assignment.

Grading Criteria	Grade Points
Case Analysis and Theoretical Approach	20 Points
Evidence and Support	20 Points
Analysis and use of Course Concepts	20 Points
Professional Ethics	20 Points
Cultural Competence	20 Points
Total	100 Points

Course Policies

Late Assignments

Graduate students are expected to submit all assignments by the due dates stated in the syllabus. A late assignment is one that is submitted after the due date and time or after any extension has expired.

If circumstances prevent a student from meeting the due date, students should contact the instructor and request an extension at least 48 hours prior to the date the assignment is due. Emergency situations will be considered on a case-by-case basis. Being busy, pressured with outside work, or having competing academic commitments are not usually considered valid reasons to receive extensions.

A student who receives an extension in advance of the due date and abides by the agreement with the instructor is not subject to late penalties. The guideline for late penalties is a deduction of one point per day from the overall grade for the first 10 days and 5 points per day after 10 days. Instructors may vary these guidelines in response to the specific conditions and requirements of each course. In the absence of an alternative announced by the Instructor the default policy is the general guideline cited above. Assignments may be re-written only with the express consent of the Instructor and under exceptional circumstances.

Participation

All MC courses encourage active engagement in discussion, dialogue, role plays and similar exercises in order to receive the maximum educational benefits. Participation includes constructive criticism and the negotiation of different perspectives and ideas. Recognizing that there are many forms of participation a range of forms and styles are welcomed. Active engagement means being attentive. Similarly, it is recognized that there are situations in which learning to hold one's counselor to not participate verbally are valuable learning experiences.

Consistent attendance and a willingness to be actively involved in classroom discussions, small group activities, and at times classroom presentations or role plays assists in creating a vibrant learning community.

Many MC courses include a participation component and, in some cases, assignments specify that participation will be graded. In such cases the criteria for participation will be made known along with the requirements for grade achievement.

Professional Writing

Assignments require error-free writing that uses standard English conventions and logical flow of organization to address topics clearly, completely, and concisely. CityU requires the use of APA style.

University Policies

Students are responsible for understanding and adhering to all of CityU's academic policies. The most current versions of these policies can be found in the [University Catalog](#) that is linked from the CityU Web site.

Non-Discrimination & Prohibition of Sexual Harassment

City University of Seattle, its staff and its faculty are deeply committed to supporting our students. We value equity, diversity, and inclusion as a way of life as well as for the educational opportunities it provides. CityU will not tolerate any form of discrimination based on race, color, ethnicity, sexual orientation, gender identification, socioeconomic status, or religious values. Any student who has experienced discrimination based on the above criteria is encouraged to report this to the University. Students may report an experience of discrimination to their course instructor. If they do not feel safe reporting to their instructor, students may report an experience of discrimination directly to the university Provost or the Vice President of Student Affairs.

CityU adheres to all federal, state, and local civil rights laws prohibiting discrimination in employment and education. The University is committed to ensuring that the education environment is bounded by standards of mutual respect and safety and is free from discriminatory practices.

In the U.S., the University is required by Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 to ensure that all of its education programs and activities do not discriminate on the basis of sex/gender. Sex include sex, sex stereotypes, gender identity, gender expression, sexual orientation, and pregnancy or parenting status. Sexual harassment, sexual assault, dating and domestic violence, and stalking are forms of sex discrimination, which are prohibited under Title IX and by CityU policy. CityU also prohibits retaliation against any person opposing discrimination or participating in any discrimination investigation or complaint process internal or external to the institution. Questions regarding Title IX, including its application and/or concerns about noncompliance, should be directed to the Title IX Coordinator. For more information visit [Title IX Policy and Contact Information](#).

In Canada, in compliance with the British Columbia Human Rights Code, the Alberta Human Rights Act, WorksafeBC, and the Workers' Compensation Board of Alberta, the University believes that its environment should at all times be supportive and respectful of the dignity and self-esteem of individuals. Discrimination, harassment and bullying conduct, whether through person-to-person behaviour or via electronic communications such as email or social media is not acceptable and will not be tolerated. As an educational institution, it is our responsibility to cultivate an environment of excellence, equity, mutual respect and to recognize the value and potential of every individual. The University will take all necessary steps to meet or exceed the requirements of the law to prevent discrimination, harassment and bullying. Information on the prevention of discrimination, harassment and bullying can be found at [Canada's Respectful Workplace Policy](#).

Religious Accommodations

CityU has a policy for accommodation of student absences or significant hardship due to reasons of faith or conscience, or for organized religious activities. The University's policy, including more information about how to request an accommodation, is available in the University Catalog and on the my.cityu.edu student portal. Accommodations must be requested by the 20% mark of this course (e.g. day 14 of a ten-week course, day 7 of a 5-week course) using the Religious Accommodations Request Form found on the student dashboard in the my.cityu.edu student portal.

Academic Integrity

Academic integrity in students requires the pursuit of scholarly activity that is free from fraud, deception and unauthorized collaboration with other individuals. Students are responsible for understanding CityU's policy on academic integrity and adhering to its standards in meeting all course requirements. A complete copy of this policy can be found in the [University Catalog](#) under *Student Rights and Responsibilities* on the page titled *Academic Integrity Policy*.

Attendance

Students taking courses in any format at the University are expected to be diligent in their studies and attend class regularly. Regular class attendance/contact is important in achieving learning outcomes in the course and correlates in many cases with participation. As such it may be a valid consideration in determining the final grade. At the beginning of each course, the instructor will inform students of the relevance of class attendance/contact to the final grade.

Attendance in this class is vital to learning the required course material and demonstrates professionalism and respect for fellow students and the instructor. All students are required to attend every class for the full duration of the class. Arriving late or leaving early will constitute an unexcused absence. It is expected that students who will not be attending or who will be arriving late notify the instructor before class starts.

Excused absences are limited to ILLNESS OR EMERGENCY. Absences related to illness may require verification from a medical doctor. All other absences will be considered unexcused.

In the event of inclement weather, students will be notified by a CityU representative and / or faculty of site closures. As student and faculty safety is a priority, students who feel that driving conditions are unsafe will be permitted an excused absence without penalty. Students are responsible for notifying the instructor before class starts that they will not be attending class due to inclement weather.

Students with more than 2 unexcused absences will be directed to meet with the local Program Director to discuss continued participation in the course. 3% of students' overall course grade will be deducted for each unexcused absence.

A complete copy of CityU's policy can be found in the [University Catalog](#) under *Student Rights and Responsibilities* on the page titled *Attendance*.

Final Assignment Due Date

Final assignments for each class at CityU must be due on or before the final date of the course as indicated in the university's course information system. Due dates that extend beyond the final date of the course may negatively impact tuition funding for students.

Sensitive Content Notice

Because the counselling profession is designed to explore the inner life of individuals, certain content discussed in CityU's Master of Counselling courses may be emotionally activating for students. The university's goal is to empower students to practice active self-care throughout their time in the program. Active self-care is an ethical responsibility for those in self-regulating professions and assists clinicians in successfully meeting clients in spaces where emotionally sensitive content is present. Similarly, in the Master of Counselling program, an ethic of care for the self is a critical consideration.

Emotionally sensitive content involves a wide variety of topics including, but not limited to, abuse, assault, neglect, self-harm, identity, sexuality, appearance, misogyny, classism, racialized issues, colonization, religious practices, trauma, grieving, ageism, caregiving, and physical or mental

health. Students are encouraged to carefully attend to their emotional wellbeing when reading, listening to, viewing, or participating in course activities involving sensitive content.

It is important to note that exploring sensitive content is an inherent part of the counselling profession. However, the complexity of human experience means students' personal histories may become activated to the point that effective learning is no longer feasible. In such cases, students are encouraged to prioritize balancing their emotional wellbeing with their professional growth. This may be done through timely self-reflection and communication with instructors and/or peers about the self-regulation strategies students will implement while engaging sensitive content.

As part of their professional growth, students are also encouraged to pursue personal counselling related to sensitive content explored in the program. Personal counselling deepens students' learning and provides insight into their future clients' experiences of the therapeutic process. Additional resources available to students include the Empower Me Program, Self-Care folders in Brightspace, and local campus wellness initiatives.

Support Services

Disability Services Accommodations Statement

Students with a documented disability who wish to request academic accommodations are encouraged to contact Disability Support Services to discuss accommodation requests and eligibility requirements. Please contact Disability Support Services at disability@cityu.edu or 206.239.4571 or visit [Academic Accommodation Services](#). Confidentiality will be observed in all inquiries. Once approved, information about academic accommodations will be shared with course instructors.

Library Services

CityU librarians are available to help students find the resources and information they need to succeed in this course. Contact a CityU librarian through the [Ask a Librarian Services](#), or access [library resources and services online](#) 24 hours a day, seven days a week.

Brainfuse Tutoring

All students receive free, unlimited tutoring through Brainfuse. To gain access, click on the **Help** button from within your Brightspace class and select the **Brainfuse** link. Resources include live tutoring, a Writing Lab, expert Q & A, and the ability to create flashcards, online quizzes/games, study groups, video notes, and record tutoring sessions.

Master of Counselling's Professional Code (2.0)

In addition to City University's general student code of conduct located in the Registrar's City U Calendar, counselling students are further expected to conduct themselves in a manner that is consistent with the core values of the profession they are entering. Students will be encouraged to adopt the following behaviours and are accountable to their peers, faculty, and CityU to sincerely undertake the development of these hallmarks of maturity:

1. Respect the dignity of classmates, faculty, and administrators without prejudice in all forms of behaviour and communication in matters of race, religion, skin colour, ethnicity, gender, orientation, physical presentation, age, ancestry or birthplace. This includes, but is not limited to, standing up against and/or reporting behaviours such as bullying, scapegoating, gossip, slander etc.
2. Maintain a positive approach to managing course-related, administrative, or relationship challenges in line with the core values of the profession. This includes, but is not limited to, directly approaching specific individuals regarding concerns of note and attempting to collaborate and independently problem-solve prior to involving faculty or administrators in the matter. Students who feel unable to independently resolve the issue should seek the support of cohort representatives, faculty, or staff.
3. Demonstrate exemplary personal conduct consistent with the values of the profession including integrity, accountability, reflexivity, generosity, compassion, inclusiveness, honesty, courage, maturity, thoughtfulness, good judgment, patience, and fairness. Demonstrate a commitment to modelling the standards and ethics of the counselling profession in all aspects of personal conduct in both the university and community at large.
4. Access City University's campuses or resources ONLY with approval from an authorized representative of the university.
5. Recognize that students with formal academic accommodations are expected to meet the same academic standards as their peers with the help of additional supports and reasonable, penalty free extensions.
6. Recognize that consistent face-to-face and online class attendance is a basic, non-negotiable requirement of the program and that the program's attendance policies will be enforced without exception. Students who are absent for any reason are required to make up all instructional hours and assignments at the discretion of the instructor.
7. Ensure that all requests for assignment extensions (with and without accommodations) are submitted to faculty a minimum of 48 hours in advance of the assignment due date. Extensions may not be granted after assignment due dates have passed.
8. Respect and behave in accordance with the appropriate professional boundaries inherent in faculty, administrative, and evaluative roles.
9. As an ambassador for the City University program, conduct themselves in a manner that strengthens the reputation of the profession, one's peers, and the program.
10. Actively develop and practice the core counselling skills of attunement, presence, and empathy in all program-related interpersonal interactions.
11. Respond to feedback from faculty and administrators in ways that facilitate personal growth, preserve our collaborative learning environment, and reflect the standards of the counselling profession.
12. Balance enthusiastic contributions to classroom discussion with ensuring there is sufficient space for all voices to be heard. This involves actively staying aware of the dynamics of class discussions and actively encouraging everyone's participation.
13. Commit to active course participation that contributes to one's own and others learning.
14. Embrace both positive and challenging academic learning opportunities and consider how these experiences can be applied in the service of personal and professional growth.